



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 12

The Professional Kitchen: Line, Plating & Career

Bring it all together at professional pace: timing, plating, and a real path into the industry.

Weeks 22-24 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Run a 'service': cook multiple dishes to land together, hot and on time.
- 2 Plate with composition, height, sauce, and garnish.
- 3 Understand the brigade system and kitchen roles.
- 4 Plan a realistic path: stages, apprenticeships, portfolio, certifications.

LESSON 12.1

Mise en Place at Scale and Timing

Objective: Cook multiple dishes so they finish together, hot and on time.

Key points

- Prep and arrange all components before service begins.
- Cook backward from serving time; know what holds and what fires late.
- 'Firing' = starting final cooks so components peak together.
- Sequencing multiple dishes is a practiced skill, not a talent.

Technique

- 1 Prep**
Make every component you can ahead; label and store.
- 2 Timeline**
Write a backward schedule from serving time.
- 3 Set the station**
Arrange tools and components for the firing order.
- 4 Fire**
Start final cooks in sequence so everything lands together.

LESSON 12.2

Plating

Objective: Plate with composition, height, sauce, and garnish.

Key points

- Establish a focal point and use negative space.
- Build height and layers; place sauce with intention.
- Garnish must be edible and relevant, not mere decoration.
- Wipe the plate clean; every element should earn its place.

Watch out for

- Overcrowding the plate so nothing stands out.
- Drowning the dish in sauce instead of placing it.
- Garnishing with inedible or pointless flourishes.

LESSON 12.3

The Brigade and Kitchen Roles

Objective: Understand how professional kitchens are organized.

Key points

- The brigade is the kitchen's hierarchy of stations and roles.
- Chef de cuisine leads; sous chef is second; chefs de partie run stations.
- Stations include saucier, poissonnier, garde manger, and patissier.
- Clear roles and crisp communication keep service coordinated.

Watch out for

- Assuming a kitchen is a free-for-all rather than a structured team.
- Not knowing the common station names when you walk in.
- Underestimating how much teamwork drives a service.

LESSON 12.4

Your Career Path

Objective: Plan a realistic route into professional cooking.

Key points

- Many chefs are self-taught; demonstrated skill and reliability matter most.
- A stage (working trial) is a common way in - and a way to learn.
- Build a portfolio: photos, menus, and recipes of your work.
- Pick a target - line cook, private chef, caterer - and plan toward it.

Watch out for

- Waiting to feel 'ready' instead of seeking real kitchen experience.
- No portfolio or record of what you can do.
- Drifting without a concrete next step or target role.

Practice & homework

1

Cook a full three-course meal for guests, plated, all landing on time.

2

Photograph your three best plates and write a short tasting note for each.

3

Draft a 12-month plan: skills to drill, a target stage, and a portfolio outline.

Watch & learn (free)



Brian Lagerstrom (ex-restaurant pro, approachable)

<https://www.youtube.com/@BrianLagerstrom>



ChefSteps (modern technique & sous vide)

<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxD2E-bVoUbaVFL0Q3PvJTg>



Pro Home Cooks (skill-building series)

<https://www.youtube.com/@ProHomeCooks>



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You've reached the end - now go cook, and keep a journal.

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM